

A group of students and a professor are gathered around a table, working on laptops. The students are of various ethnicities and are focused on their work. The professor, a man with a beard, is leaning over the table, looking at the laptops. In the background, there is a dartboard on the wall and a large black speaker on a stand.

Preliminary Study & Master Thesis

Lucerne University of Applied Sciences and Arts
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Information Event, November 2025

What applies to everyone -
regardless of the
Master's Thesis format chosen

The Master's thesis is your **MASTERPIECE**.
Use this time to set an exclamation
mark for yourself!



Aim of the Master's thesis project

Completion of the Master's thesis project is deemed as proof that the student is able to complete an **academically challenging project** in research or an applied field independently **within a given period** and **devise an appropriate and meaningful solution** that fully **meets current academic standards**. Furthermore, students must demonstrate that they can complete the written components of the Master's thesis project by using correct language, form and style and by structuring the content logically.

Source: Master of Science in Applied Information and Data Science. Regulations for the Preliminary Study and the Master's thesis, p. 3 (Version of 17 April 2024).

Please be aware: **The Master's thesis is your masterpiece**. It represents a significant proportion of your total study workload. You will have a steep learning curve. The Master's thesis is often an excellent door-opener to interesting employers.

Find your own topic

Students must find suitable **topics on their own**; however, the heads of the program and all lecturers can suggest topics as well. These can be based on requests from internal and external clients or be part of a research project. It is possible to write the Master's thesis within the framework of an existing employment relationship - for the current employer. Academic standards must be met in all cases.

Please note that we provide a growing number of topics through our “rent a student” platform. Anyway, start looking for topics as early as possible!

Requirements for MT topics

The topic of the Master's thesis project must meet the following conditions:

- The content must **relate to a specialised field** of the program.
- The project must require students to **use the knowledge and skills they acquired and developed during the program**. A topic can also require students to include other fields they learned about while working on the project.
- The **scope and complexity of the topic must match the level of the program** and the time available for completing the project.
- The project must be **clearly defined and well structured**.
- The Project must focus on an **applied field or entrepreneurial initiative**, and its successful completion must result in a clear benefit for the client.

Source: Master of Science in Applied Information and Data Science. Regulations for the Preliminary Study and the Master's thesis, p. 3 (Version of 1 March 2025).

Decide on the issue with **head**, but also with **heart**.

Formats for MT Projects

Focus:

- **Academic research**

- **Applied research**

- **Entrepreneurial initiative**

Aim

- high quality, academic research report/paper

- significant contribution to the solution of a real-life business challenge

- clear benefit for the project partner

- innovative data product/service

Supervisor and Co-Supervisor

The supervisor is responsible for supervising all aspects of the Master's thesis project.

- The supervisor must be a **member of the internal teaching staff of the Master's program**. With the head of program's approval, **external lecturers, as well as internal lecturers who do not teach in the program** but are experts in the field, can also supervise a Master's thesis.
- In addition, **a co-supervisor is assigned to the Master's thesis**. The supervisor has the right of proposal. External or internal clients who sponsor a Master's thesis project usually also serve as the co-supervisor in such a case.
- The **head of program can approve a change of supervisor** if there are objective reasons for doing so. A change of supervisor may mark a second attempt at the project (as a rule).

Admission to the Master's thesis

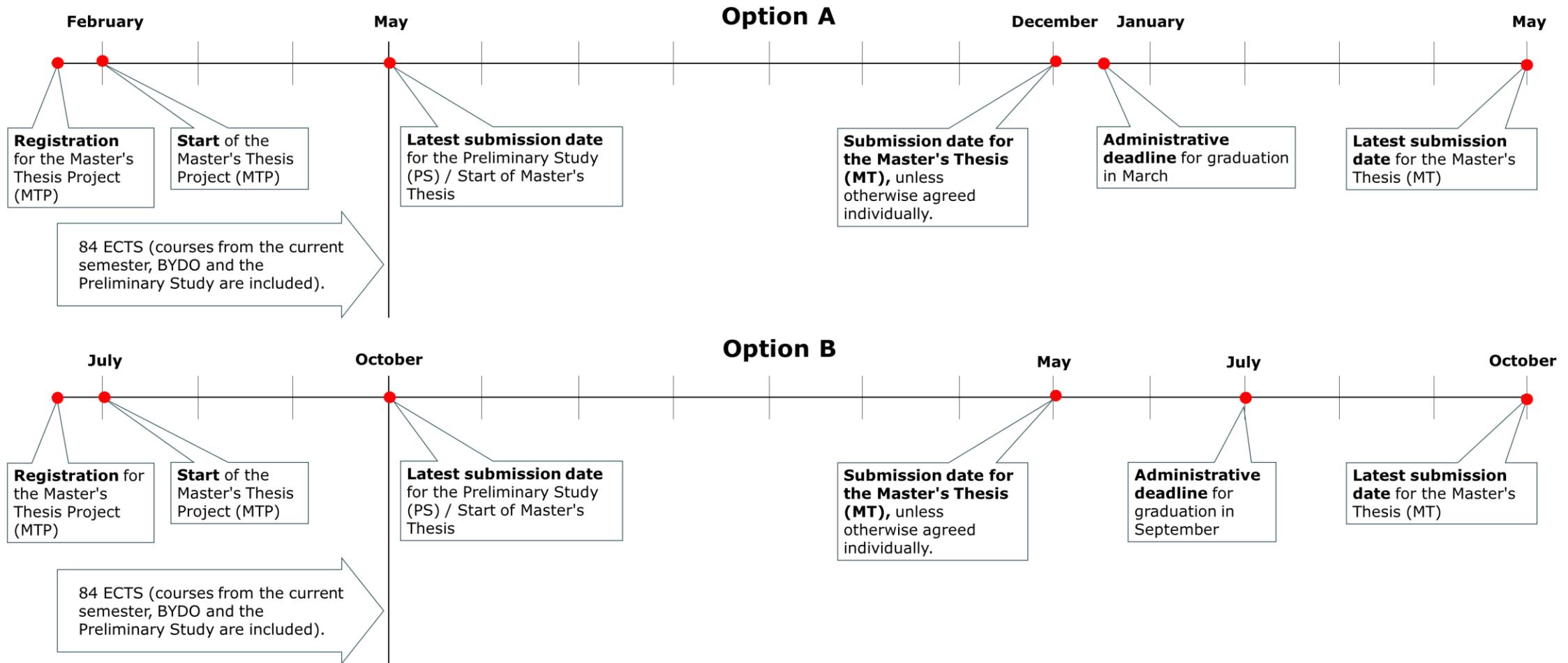
Students are admitted to the Master thesis if

- a. the preliminary study received **a grade of 4.0 or higher**,
- b. modules to the extent of **at least 84 ECTS credits** have been attended. ^{1,2)}

- ¹⁾ The start of the Master's thesis can be approved **even if the repetition of credits in individual modules is still pending.**
- ²⁾ The decisive factor is that students have *enrolled* for 84 ECTS. **This means that the modules of the current semester are also counted.**

Please be aware that the Master's thesis is very time-consuming. We highly recommend minimizing the study load during the preparation of the Master's thesis.

Timeframe of Master's Thesis Project (Option A & B)



Registration for the Master's thesis project

Registration form:

- A valid registration must contain the **minimum information**.
- The registration for the Master's thesis project **is binding**.

Registration is possible even if the supervisor's commitment is still pending and the topic is not yet defined. It is in the interest of the candidates to determine the supervisor as early as possible. The definitive topic, the supervisor and co-supervisor of the MT must be fixed with the submission of the preliminary study.

Using artificial intelligence (e.g. ChatGPT)

Rules:

- GenAI aids **are permitted** for the preparation of the preliminary study and the Master's thesis.
- The students indicate the way they use GenAI in a [declaration](#) provided for this purpose.
- GenAI is **not a referenceable academic source**.

The use of GenAI is at the student's own responsibility. The (general) use must be declared. The use of GenAI has no influence on the assessment of the preliminary study or master's thesis.

Scientific writing...

- You are earning an academic degree.
- The master's thesis has a minimal scientific standard.
- Scientific writing is a matter of practice.
- **Certain formal aspects, such as the citation style, can be agreed upon individually with the supervisor.**

If you don't feel confident, take the Scientific Writing module.

Complexis - central administration of PMT and MT

Rules:

- All administrative processes related to PMT and MT are now centrally administered (Complexis).
- In Complexis, MT topics are created and validated, PMT and MT are uploaded and evaluated.
- The Transfer Service is now responsible for all administrative questions in connection with PMT and MT.
- <https://complexis.hslu.ch/home>
- <https://www.hslu.ch/de-ch/wirtschaft/forschung/transfer-services/>

Transfer Services is now responsible for all administrative issues - from registration to submission of the MT. **Programme Management** remains responsible for all content-related issues and matters requiring applications (e.g. extension of deadlines).

Non Disclose Agreement (NDA) / Property Rights

- There is a [template](#) that governs confidentiality and property rights. But: Most companies bring in their own NDAs.
- However, the programme management does not accept any provision in such agreements with financial penalties or provisions that make retention, cataloguing, checking (plagiarism check), etc. impossible.
- Such agreements must usually be signed by three parties: 1) the student, 2) the supervisors and 3) the programme management.

If in doubt, always consult the programme management.

“Classical Model” (extended
Master’s thesis-Project)

“New Model” (shortened
Master’s thesis-Project)

General Framework “Classical Model”

1. Preliminary Study (6 ECTS)
2. Main Study (24 ECTS)
3. Mandatory Defense
4. Project internship possible, but **NOT MANDATORY**
5. ECTS credits earned through project placements count for 'Elective Modules'.

Master of Science in Applied Information and Data Science. Regulations for the Preliminary Study and the Master's thesis ([Version of 1 March 2025](#)).

General Framework “New Model”

1. Preliminary Study (3 ECTS)
2. Main Study (15 ECTS)
3. Mandatory Defense
4. Project internship **MANDATORY** (12 ECTS)
5. Students who lack ECTS credits from the project internship must **take additional advanced modules to compensate** for the missing ECTS credits.

Master of Science in Applied Information and Data Science. Regulations for the Preliminary Study and the Master's thesis ([Version of 4 March 2025](#)). Please read the regulations carefully.

Master's Thesis Project (Models)

	Master's thesis project (extended; without bydo)	Master's thesis project (extended; with bydo)	Master's thesis project (shortened; with bydo)
Master's thesis project	Preliminary study: 6 ECTS Main study & defence: 24 ECTS	Preliminary study: 6 ECTS Main study & defence: 24 ECTS	Preliminary study: 3 ECTS Main study & defence: 15 ECTS
bydo (<12 ECTS)		Counts towards "elective modules"	Exception: Students attend additional "advanced modules" as compensation (<u>is only granted under specific and restrictive conditions</u>).
bydo (=12 ECTS)		Counts towards "elective modules"	Qualifies for the short Master's thesis project

Relationship between Project Internship (bydo) and Master's Thesis Project

Playing by the rules

1. The Project Internship (bydo) and the Master's Thesis Project are **separate modules**.
2. The Project Internship (bydo) and the Master's Thesis Project can be linked in terms of content. However, they can also cover completely different topics.
3. The Master's Thesis Project **is always an individual achievement** and not a team effort.
4. If the Project Internship (bydo) and the Master's Thesis Project are related in content, the Master's Thesis Project **must represent a clearly distinguishable individual achievement**.
5. The **same work cannot be credited to both the Project Internship (bydo) and the Master's Thesis Project**.
6. Failure to comply with these conditions will **result in failure of the Master's thesis**. In cases of deliberate deception, further disciplinary action may be taken.

Content of the Preliminary Study (extended version)

Preliminary study (more research-oriented)

1. Cover page
2. Background
3. Topic definition
4. Main research question(s)
5. Methodology
6. Underlying data
7. Technology/software/applications
8. Annotated disposition (story line)
9. Project risks

Preliminary study (more research-oriented)

- 10. Work and research plan
- 11. **Structured and annotated list of sources and/or literature**
- 12. Appendix/appendices (if applicable)

With the consent of the supervisor, the disposition may be adjusted to the focus of the MT !!

Please do not underestimate the importance of the Preliminary study for the success of the Master's thesis. Especially the sections "data" (point 6) and "project risks" (point 9) are of central importance.

Content of the Preliminary Study (shortened version)

Preliminary study (more tech paper-oriented)

1. **Cover page:** Contains working title, student, course of study, supervisors, co-supervisors, clients, place/date, Lucerne University of Applied Sciences and Arts.
2. **Problem statement and motivation:** Describes the initial situation, the problem and its relevance for science or practice.
3. **Core research question and objective:** Formulates the research question and the objective of the Master's Thesis and describes the expected innovation.
4. **Definition of the topic:** Clarifies the content-related and methodological boundaries of the Master's Thesis.
5. **Initial considerations regarding methodology:** Contains initial considerations regarding the method, relevant literature or technologies.
6. **Data:** Contains a description of the necessary data and initial considerations regarding data collection.

Preliminary study (more tech paper-oriented)

7. **Technical requirements:** Describes the necessary software, frameworks, platforms and technical resources.
8. **Project risks and challenges:** Contains possible content-related, methodological or technical risks as well as strategies for risk minimization.
9. **Work packages and schedule:** Describes the main phases of the Master's Thesis, defines the work packages and the individual tasks with an estimated time requirement, and includes a schedule with resource planning (e.g. availability of data, supervisors, etc.), milestones and deadlines.

With the consent of the supervisor, the disposition may be adjusted to the focus of the MT !!

Please do not underestimate the importance of the Preliminary study for the success of the Master's thesis. Especially the sections "data" (point 6) and "project risks" (point 9) are of central importance.

Content of the Preliminary Study (shortened version)

A few statements/learnings of your fellows

(unordered)

- Preliminary Study has a very very high importance...
- Above all, the data basis should be clarified very carefully... it's all about data, data, data...
- The work plan should be worked out as carefully as possible - and then be sure to stick to that plan...
- Do not make the project too ambitious...
- Use the time to read up on the research literature. Afterward, time is very often lacking...
- Data preparation (Extract, Transform, Load ETL processes) take a lot more time than you think (> 60 %)...
- Find a working mode with the supervisor from the beginning...
- ...

A few statements/learnings of your fellows

(unordered)

- It is necessary to plan for time reserves...
- Document your work systematically. Make a lot of annotations in your programs so that you can understand the programs later...
- Work on your work without longer breaks. Maintain a minimum intensity while working on the Master's thesis...
- Use the Preliminary study to dive deeply into the research literature...
- Have the courage to start writing very early...
- Always use a method that is as simple as possible, but one that achieves the goal. Often you can achieve more than 80% of the desired performance. The last 20% are very hard...
- ...

Accidents and other disasters

Changing the Supervisor: The Head of program can approve a change of lecturer if there are objective reasons for doing so. A change of lecturer marks a second attempt at the project (as a rule).

Changing the topic: Possible at any time during the preliminary study; not possible during the Master's thesis (as a rule).

Termination of the project: The Head of program can terminate the Master's thesis project if the maximum extension period is/seems to be insufficient, in which case the project is deemed to not have been started. In such a case, the student can submit a new proposal in the following semester.

Failing with the possibility of compensation (Preliminary Study): In cases where the Preliminary Study results in a rounded grade of 3.5, the student has the opportunity to revise it to bring the initial grade up to a 4.0.

Failing without the possibility of compensation (Preliminary Study): In cases where the Preliminary Study results in a grade below 3.5, the student can start over with a new topic. Students can repeat the project at the earliest in the following semester.

Accidents and other disasters

Failing with the possibility of compensation (Master's thesis): In cases where the Master's thesis results in a rounded grade of 3.5, the student can submit an additional piece of work to bring the initial grade up to a 4.0. If the Master's thesis must be revised, the lecturer will provide the student with a specific task. Students can choose whether to submit the revised version in the current or the following semester.

Failing without the possibility of compensation (Master's thesis): Students who achieve a grade below a 3.5 on their Master's thesis can repeat it once with a new topic. Students can re-register for the Master's thesis project only in the following semester.

Illness: The provisions of the Academic Regulations apply to students who become ill and can no longer work on their Master's thesis project, in which case the Head of Program must be informed immediately. Furthermore, the student must provide a medical certificate right away. The Head of Program will decide on any further steps to take.

There are many reasons that make it impossible or unreasonable to continue or successfully complete a Master's thesis. In cases where these reasons are not self-inflicted, a bilateral discussion with the director of the programme will always help.

Do you have any questions? —

now or later?



GOOD LUCK !!!

